

Odd and Hybrid Fronts: 3-4, Okie, Tite, and Modern Nickel Fronts

Why the graphic says 3-4 and you count four men on the line, why the best run defenses of the light-box era wall off the middle with three big bodies, and how to read a front whose name keeps changing

The graphic in the corner of the screen says the defense is in a **3-4**. You count. Four players at the line of scrimmage, two of them standing up, two with a hand on the ground. Next snap, same eleven defenders, no substitution: now there are *five* across the line, three of them enormous and wedged inside the offensive tackles, with a single linebacker behind them. The offense hands the ball to its running back on an inside run, the kind that worked all afternoon last week, and he runs into a wall two yards deep. No blocker ever touched the linebacker. “That’s their tite front,” says the analyst. “Three big bodies inside, and nobody can get to the second level.” So which is it: a 3-4, a four-man line, a five-man line? And how did a defense with only six men near the ball stop a run aimed at six blockers? This chapter is about the other family of fronts, the *odd* ones, and about why, in the modern game, the names on the graphic tell you less than the picture on the field.

You’ll be able to:

- Look at a front before the snap, find whether anyone is head-up on the center, and say whether it is odd or even.
- Diagram the 3-4 Okie, and tell from the linemen’s alignment and first step whether it is being played two-gap (control and read) or one-gap (attack).
- Recognize a tite (or mint) front, explain why it walls off inside runs against spread offenses, and name what it gives up.
- Identify the nickel fronts (4-2-5, 3-3-5, 2-4-5) by counting hands on the ground and players standing on the edges, and explain why a roster label and the picture so often disagree.
- Explain how a defense picks a front to stop inside zone and a different one to stop outside zone.
- Decode front dialect (Okie, Eagle, G, reduced) and know when one word means different things in different buildings.

You’ll need

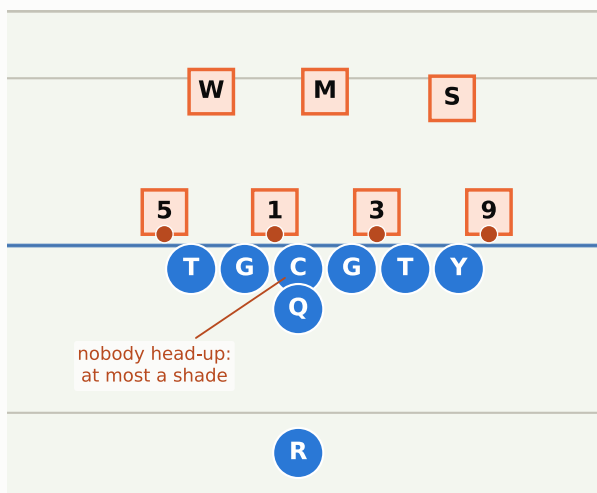
- **Even Fronts:** an **even front** has nobody head-up on the center (the 4-3 *Over* puts its 3-technique toward the tight end, the *Under* away from him), and every even front has a rule, usually tied to the tight end, that tells you where the linemen will line up.
- **Defensive Line Play:** technique numbers from the defense’s side (the 0 nose, the 3, the 4i, 4 and 5 on the tackle, the 9 and the wide-9), one-gap versus two-gap, setting the edge and contain.
- **A First Look at Defense:** base defenses (the 4-3 and the 3-4), nickel, the box and the light box, and two-high safety shells.
- **Zone Running:** inside and outside zone, double teams that climb to linebackers, and the cutback.

How to read the diagrams. As in the rest of Part 5: offense is blue circles, defense orange squares, plays go up the page, and *left* and *right* are always the offense’s left and right. Defensive linemen are labelled with their **technique number** (a 0 is a nose head-up on the center, a 4i is on a tackle’s inside shoulder). **E** is an *edge* player standing up at the end of the line; **M** and **W** are inside linebackers; **\$** is the nickel back; **C** a cornerback; **FS** and **SS** the safeties. New in this chapter: **a dark dot on the front edge of a defender’s square is a hand on the ground**. A square with no dot is a player standing up. Counting dots is how you will tell fronts apart, because counting players stopped working a long time ago.

Odd and even: who is on the center?

Every front in football starts with one question, and you can answer it from the couch: **is anybody lined up head-up on the center?**

Even: nobody on the center



Odd: a nose on the center

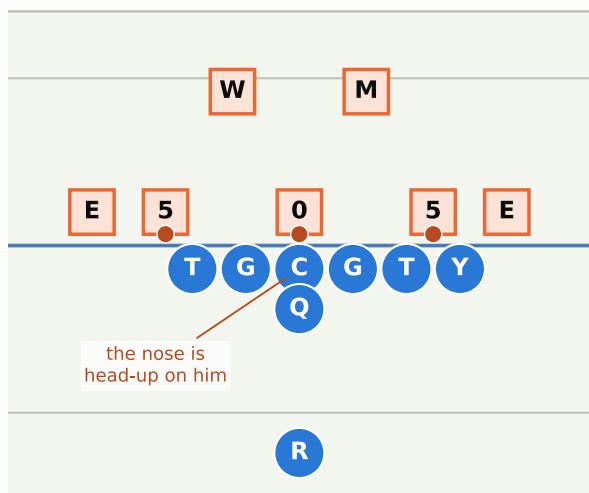


Figure 1: The one-glance test. Left, an even front (the 4-3 Over of Even Fronts): the two defensive tackles split the center between them, one shaded on his shoulder (the 1) and one outside a guard (the 3), and nobody stands directly over the ball. Right, an odd front (the 3-4 Okie of this chapter): a nose tackle head-up on the center (the 0), with an end on each offensive tackle and a stand-up edge (E) at each end of the line. Dark dots are hands on the ground: four in the even front, three in the odd one. Both have seven players in the front.

If nobody is head-up on the center, the front is **even**: the defensive tackles line up on or around the guards, the center is *uncovered* or only shaded, and you are looking at one of the four-man fronts of Even Fronts. If a big man stands right over the ball, nose to nose with the center, the front is **odd**: it is balanced around a **0-technique** nose tackle, and the classic versions have three or five men on the line (the 3-4 and the old 5-2) rather than four.

Why does one alignment decide the family? Because of what it does to the offensive line's arithmetic. In an even front, nobody is square in front of the center: at most a tackle shaded on one of his shoulders, a man he can work on together with a guard, and often nobody at all, in which case he is free to help or to climb to a linebacker. The defense has eased the center's job in exchange for putting its tackles where they can attack the guards. In an odd front, the center has a man in his face on every snap, and a nose head-up on him can play *either* A gap, so the offense can't know where he'll go. The center is occupied, and one of the two guards usually has to help him. That is the founding idea of every odd front: **put a heavy man on the center, make the offense spend two blockers on him, and let somebody else run free**. You met that nose in Defensive Line Play. This chapter is about the fronts built around him.

A warning before we start, which the rest of the chapter will keep proving: "odd" and "even" describe *where linemen stand*, not *who is on the roster*. A team that calls itself a 3-4 team plays an even front on plenty of snaps, and a 4-3 team can put a nose on the center. Keep your eyes on the center.

The 3-4 Okie

The **3-4 Okie** is the classic 3-4, the one drawn in every coaching book: a nose head-up on the center, a defensive end on each offensive tackle, a stand-up edge at each end of the line, and two inside linebackers behind the guards. The name is short for *Oklahoma*, because the alignment is Bud Wilkinson's Oklahoma 5-2 of the late 1940s and 1950s with its two outside men standing up (more on that history below).

The 3-4 Okie vs 21 personnel

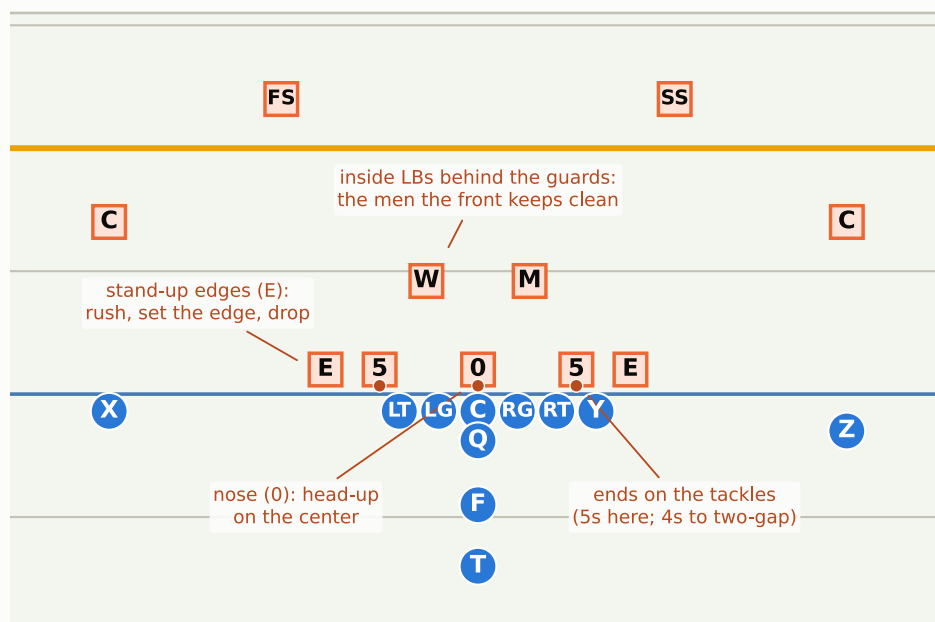


Figure 2: The 3-4 Okie against a two-back, one-tight-end offense (21 personnel, the kind of offense it was built for), all eleven defenders. Three hands on the ground: the nose (0), head-up on the center, and the two ends, here in 5-techniques on the tackles' outside shoulders (in the two-gap version they line up head-up, in a 4). At each end of the line a stand-up edge (E): on the tight-end side on Y's outside shoulder (a 9), on the open side a couple of yards outside the tackle. Two inside linebackers (M and W) stand about four and a half yards deep behind the guards, where no lineman blocks them unless a guard leaves to do it. Four defensive backs: two cornerbacks (C) on the wide receivers and two safeties (FS, SS) deep.

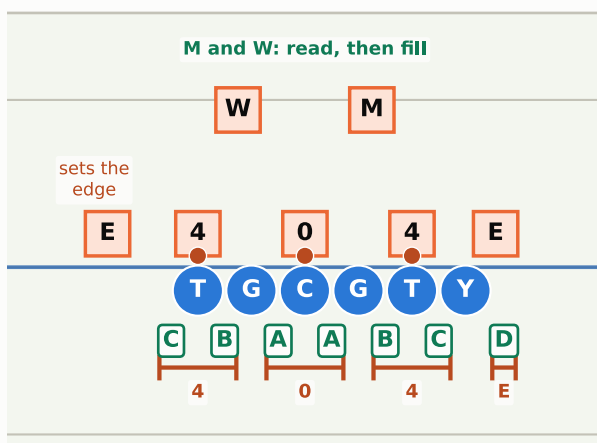
Read Figure 2 as a list of jobs, the way you learned to in Defensive Line Play.

- **The nose** takes on the center, and very often a guard as well. He is the heaviest man on the field, because his whole value is in not moving.
- **The ends** sit on the offensive tackles. In the classic version they are head-up there, in a 4-technique, and they control the tackle and play the gap on either side of him. Others line up on the tackle's outside shoulder, a 5. They are long and strong, the 290-to-310-pound bodies built to lock out a tackle at arm's length.
- **The outside linebackers** are standing up at each end of the line. Against the run they set the edge; against the pass, one or both rush; and on some snaps one drops into coverage. They are the lightest players in the front, edge rushers in all but stance.
- **The inside linebackers** stand behind the guards, and here is the design's point. Count the offensive linemen who don't have a defender on or near them before the snap: the two guards. In zone-blocking terms they are *uncovered* (Zone Running), and an uncovered guard wants to climb straight to a linebacker. The Okie's whole design is to make that impossible: the nose is too much for the center alone, so one guard has to stay and help; the ends hold the tackles so they can't climb either. If the front does its job, at most one blocker reaches the second level, and two linebackers are left to make tackles.

One alignment, two ways to play it

What the front does after the snap is a separate choice from where it lines up. A 3-4 can be a *two-gap* front, in which the three linemen control blockers and read, or a *one-gap* front, in which every defender attacks a gap at the snap. You learned the difference player by player in Defensive Line Play. Here is what each looks like across the whole front.

Two-gap 3-4: control, then read



One-gap 3-4: shaded, then attack

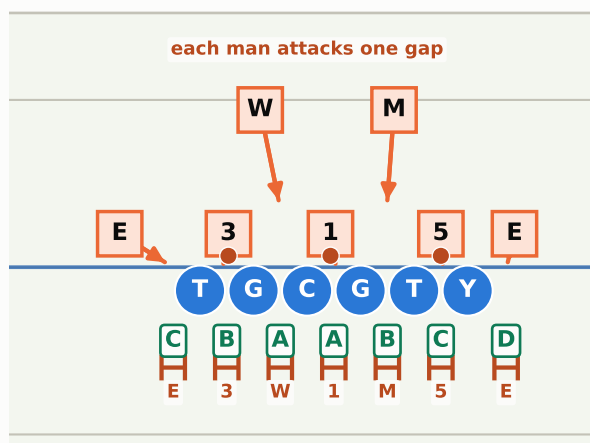


Figure 3: Two 3-4s against the same one-tight-end offense, with each defender's gaps (the bars under the gap letters) and first steps (arrows). Left, two-gap: the nose (0) and the two ends, head-up on the tackles in 4-techniques, each own the two gaps on either side of their blocker; the edge (E) on the tight end owns the D gap; the open-side edge sets the edge outside. Six gaps need only three linemen, so both inside linebackers start with no gap at all: they read and fill wherever the ball goes. Right, one-gap: the same personnel lined up shaded, each man aimed at one gap (arrows). The nose shades to the tight-end side (a 1) and attacks that A gap; the open-side end moves down to a 3 on the guard and takes the B gap; the tight-end-side end takes the C gap from a 5; the edges take the outside gaps, and the linebackers fill the two gaps left over (the Mike the B gap toward the tight end, the Will the other A gap). If you have read Even Fronts, the right-hand picture should look familiar: it is the 4-3 Under with the Sam called an outside linebacker.

The two-gap 3-4 is the old-school version, and its appeal is the math in the left half of Figure 3. Three linemen can hold six gaps if each of them can stand up a blocker and play either side of him. That leaves the two inside linebackers *gap-free*: they don't have to guess at the snap; they watch the play develop and run to the ball, and the linemen in front of them keep the blockers off them. Bill Parcells's New York Giants of the 1980s played it, with Bill Belichick as his defensive coordinator, and Belichick's New England Patriots of the 2000s played it with linemen like Vince Wilfork, Richard Seymour and Ty Warren, all built like the job: big, long and patient.¹

The cost, as Defensive Line Play explained, is that two-gappers are always reacting. They rarely make plays behind the line or sack the quarterback, they need bodies the draft produces only a few of each year, and on passing downs the defense usually has to take the nose off for someone quicker.

The one-gap 3-4 keeps the personnel and changes the job. Line the ends up shaded into gaps, shade the nose, and tell every defender to attack his gap at the snap, and the 3-4 becomes an attacking front. The right half of Figure 3 shows the most common way to do it, and it holds a secret: lined up this way, a "3-4" is almost exactly the 4-3 Under of Even Fronts, a nose shaded to the tight end, a 3-technique away from him, a 5 and a 9 to the tight end's side, with the Sam linebacker called an outside linebacker and standing up. The roster says 3-4. The football says Under.

That is why "3-4" by itself is a weak clue. The number of linemen tells you how many there are; their alignment and **first step** tell you how they play. A two-gapper's first step goes *into the blocker*, hands first, and he stays at the line. A one-gapper's goes *into a gap*, and he is across the line before the blocker has finished his first step. Watch the ends for two snaps and you will know which 3-4 you are watching.

¹Belichick was the Giants' defensive coordinator under Parcells from 1985 to 1990: Pro Football Hall of Fame, Bill Parcells, <https://www.profootballhof.com/players/bill-parcells/>, and "Bill Belichick," Wikipedia, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Bill_Belichick. The Patriots' two-gap 3-4 and its linemen (Wilfork, Seymour, Warren): Chris B. Brown, "Ode to the War Daddies," Grantland (February 6, 2012), <https://grantland.com/features/bill-belichick-vince-wilfork-new-england-patriots-defense/>.

! Why it exists

The 3-4 trades linemen for linebackers, and two-gap play is what makes that trade affordable. Take a defensive lineman off the field and put a linebacker on, and you gain a player who can rush, drop into coverage or fill a run lane, and who keeps the offense guessing which of those he'll do. You lose one big body at the line. The two-gap 3-4 covers the loss with technique: three linemen hold six gaps, and the linebackers run free. The one-gap 3-4 covers it with movement and speed: every man attacks, and the extra linebacker is just one more fast player who can come from anywhere. Either way, the defense is betting that a fourth linebacker is worth more than a fourth lineman. In an era of spread offenses, three-receiver sets and quarterbacks who throw on first down, that bet has mostly paid.

Where the 3-4 came from (and why nobody agrees)

Ask who invented the 3-4 and you will get at least four answers, each true about something. The honest version is a family tree, not a birth certificate.

The ancestors: five men on the line. In 1947 Earle "Greasy" Neale, the Philadelphia Eagles' head coach, who had also played outfield for the Cincinnati Reds in the 1919 World Series, built his defense around a five-man line with two linebackers behind it. It was called the **Eagle defense**, and the Eagles won NFL championships with it in 1948 and 1949.² Bud Wilkinson took the five-man line to the University of Oklahoma, where it became the **Oklahoma 5-2**, the defense behind his Sooners' 47-game winning streak in the 1950s. (That is where *Okie* comes from.) Now look at a 5-2 the way a coach of the 1970s did. The two men at the ends of the line were defensive ends, but they were usually smaller and quicker than the three linemen inside them, and their jobs were to set the edge and, on some plays, to drop. Stand them up, call them linebackers, and the same seven players become three linemen and four linebackers. Nobody had to invent the 3-4; it was hiding inside the 5-2.³

The NFL arrivals, early 1970s: several claimants.

- **Bill Arnsparger, Miami, 1972.** The Dolphins' defensive coordinator under Don Shula had a linebacker, Bob Matheson, who could play with his hand on the ground or standing up. Arnsparger moved him around the front, sometimes as a fourth linebacker, sometimes as a rushing end, and the package was named for his jersey: the **53 defense**. The Dolphins went 17–0. Was it a 3-4? On some snaps, yes, and it is often named as the 3-4's NFL ancestor; the story belongs to *The 1978 Liberation*.⁴
- **Chuck Fairbanks, New England, 1974.** Fairbanks had coached the Oklahoma 5-2 as the Sooners' head coach, and when he took over the Patriots he brought it with him, standing up its ends. His 1974 Patriots are usually named as the first NFL team to use the 3-4 as their regular base defense.⁵
- **Bum Phillips, Houston, 1974–75.** Phillips, the cowboy-hatted Texan who had devised the technique numbers you have been using since *The Language of the Run Game*, was the Oilers' defensive coordinator when they traded for nose tackle Curley Culp in October 1974, and a full-time 3-4 followed when Phillips became head coach in 1975. Culp, a former heavyweight wrestling champion at Arizona State, was strong enough to need two blockers, and Phillips gave him the credit: "Curley made the 3-4 work. He made me look smart."⁶

The boom and the bust. Within a few years the 3-4 was everywhere. John Madden's Raiders switched to it in 1976, after injuries thinned their defensive line, and won the Super Bowl; Arnsparger's Dolphins went to it full time in 1977; and by the late 1970s and early 1980s it was the league's most common base defense.⁷ Then offenses changed again, the one-back passing games of the 1980s and 1990s made four-man fronts with fast defensive ends fashionable, and by the mid-1990s only a handful of teams,

²The Eagle defense ("a five-man line with two linebackers and four backs," introduced in 1947) and its line to Wilkinson's Oklahoma 5-2: "5-2 defense," Wikipedia, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/5%E2%80%932_defense. Neale's championships (1948, 1949) and his baseball career: Pro Football Hall of Fame, <https://www.profootballhof.com/players/earle-greasy-neale/>.

³Wilkinson's "5-2 Oklahoma defense" as the origin of the 3-4: "3-4 defense," Wikipedia, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/3%E2%80%934_defense. Wilkinson's 47-game winning streak (1953–57): "Bud Wilkinson," Wikipedia, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Bud_Wilkinson.

⁴"Bob Matheson," Wikipedia (acquired before the 1971 season at Arnsparger's request; the "53" defense named for his number; a precursor of the 3-4): https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Bob_Matheson. The Dolphins' 1972 season (17–0, including Super Bowl VII): "1972 Miami Dolphins season," Wikipedia, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/1972_Miami_Dolphins_season.

⁵The 1974 Patriots under Fairbanks, who had coached the 5-2 at Oklahoma, as the "first NFL team to regularly employ the 3-4": "3-4 defense," Wikipedia, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/3%E2%80%934_defense; "Chuck Fairbanks," Wikipedia, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Chuck_Fairbanks.

⁶"Curley Culp," Wikipedia (traded from Kansas City to Houston in October 1974 while Phillips was defensive coordinator; the Oilers' full commitment to the 3-4 when Phillips became head coach in 1975; his NCAA heavyweight wrestling title at Arizona State; the Phillips quotation): https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Curley_Culp. Bum Phillips and the technique numbers: *The Language of the Run Game*.

⁷"3-4 defense," Wikipedia: Madden's 1976 Raiders switching after injuries to their defensive line; the 1977 Dolphins going "full-time to the 3-4 under Arnsparger"; its peak in "the late 1970s and early 1980s"; its rarity by the mid-1990s outside Buffalo and Pittsburgh; and the Steelers' use of it as their base since 1982: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/3%E2%80%934_defense.

Pittsburgh above all, still lined up in a 3-4. The revival came in the 2000s, led by the Steelers and Belichick's Patriots, and took a new shape that the rest of this chapter is about: the stand-up edge rusher, the one-gap 3-4, and in the 2020s the five-man tite front. The longer arc, including the 3-4's role in the rise of the hybrid edge, is in *Dynasties and Counterpunches* and *The Single Wing to the Scoring Drought*.

So who invented it? Wilkinson's 5-2 supplied the alignment, Arnsperger the idea of a hybrid end-linebacker, Fairbanks and Phillips the commitment to it as a base defense, and Madden the Super Bowl that sold it. That is the usual shape of football history: a problem (offenses running more and throwing more on early downs), several smart people solving it in the same few years, and credit that depends on whom you ask.

The stand-up edge

The 3-4's most important legacy isn't the nose. It is the player at the end of the line who isn't sure whether he is a lineman or a linebacker, and doesn't need to be.

A **stand-up edge** lines up at the end of the line of scrimmage in a two-point stance, standing, instead of with a hand in the dirt. In a 3-4 he is called an **outside linebacker**, and the roster lists him that way; on the field, most snaps, he is an edge rusher doing a defensive end's job. Lawrence Taylor in the 1980s, Kevin Greene and Greg Lloyd in the 1990s, DeMarcus Ware and Von Miller in the 2000s and 2010s, T.J. Watt today: the most feared pass rushers of the 3-4 era stood up.

Why stand? Three reasons, each a trade.

1. **Vision and options.** Standing, he sees the whole backfield, and he can move in any direction at the snap: rush, take on a blocker, or turn and drop into coverage. A lineman in a three-point stance, weight forward on his hand, is committed to going forward. The offense can't rule out a drop from a standing edge, so it can't be sure who is rushing. That uncertainty is the seed of the simulated pressures of Part 7.
2. **Width and speed.** Standing, he can align wider and get to full speed sooner on an outside rush, because he is already upright.
3. **Disguise.** A front with two standing edges can become a four-man line, a five-man line or a three-man rush without anyone substituting. That is the trick behind the opening of this chapter, and it gets its own animation below.

What it costs. Mostly leverage against the run. A defender in a three-point stance comes out low, and the low man wins at the line; a standing edge has to sink as he takes on a tackle or a tight end, or he gets pushed upfield and the edge goes soft. That is why the stand-up edges who last are the ones who can set the edge as well as rush (in Defensive Line Play's terms, who keep their outside arm free against a 300-pound tackle), and why many of them put a hand down on obvious running downs. The body type is in between, too: usually 245 to 265 pounds, lighter than a defensive end, heavier than an inside linebacker. Teams that play four-man fronts draft the same players and call them defensive ends. The player is the same; the label follows the scheme.

Common misconception

"A 3-4 outside linebacker is a linebacker, so he covers people." Some do, some of the time. Most of the great ones spend the large majority of their passing-down snaps rushing the quarterback. When you see a 3-4 outside linebacker drop into coverage, it is usually a deliberate surprise, designed to put a defender where the quarterback expected an empty space, not his everyday job.

Two-gap, one-gap: the 3-4 in the modern NFL

The 3-4's revival in the 2000s split along the line from Figure 3. Belichick's Patriots and the Steelers kept versions that leaned on two-gap play up front. The other branch came from one family, the Phillipses.

Wade Phillips, Bum's son, spent four decades as a coordinator and head coach running a 3-4 that looked like his father's and played nothing like it. Phillips's linemen were shaded into gaps and attacked them; his outside linebackers rushed; the ends were penetrators, not anchors. When he took over the Houston Texans' defense in 2011, the team's own preview called it "his one-gap scheme," and the line coach said it was "not like a two-gap type defense where you need that 350-pound nose man."⁸ The proof arrived the following year, when the Texans' 5-technique end, J.J. Watt, led the league with 20.5 sacks and was Defensive Player of

⁸Houston Texans, "2011 position preview: defensive line" (September 7, 2011): Phillips "views them as a perfect fit for his one-gap scheme"; defensive line coach Bill Kollar: "We're more still of a one-gap type defense... It's not like a two-gap type defense where you need that 350-pound nose man": <https://www.houstontexans.com/news/2011-position-preview-defensive-line-5715572>.

the Year: the end of a 3-4, the position that used to exist to let linebackers make tackles, had become the defense's best pass rusher.⁹

Four years later Phillips took the same ideas to Denver, where the 2015 Broncos allowed the fewest yards in the league and won Super Bowl 50 with two stand-up edges, Von Miller and DeMarcus Ware, chasing the quarterback.¹⁰ Their film room is below.

The general lesson: “**3-4**” **names the personnel, not the play**. A two-gap 3-4 and a one-gap 3-4 use the same eleven bodies and ask opposite things of them. The modern descendants of both branches meet in one front, which is next.

The tite front: walling off the middle

The **tite front** is an odd front with five men on the line: a nose on the center, two defensive linemen in **4i-techniques** on the inside shoulders of the offensive tackles, and an edge player outside each tackle. Fangio and his coaching tree call it *tite*; Kirby Smart's Georgia calls the same picture the **mint front**; and, as the dialect section below shows, some playbooks call it *Eagle*.

It is a **reduced front** on both sides. In a reduced front, the defensive linemen slide a gap inward from their usual spots and an edge player takes the outside gap they left. The 4-3 Under of Even Fronts reduces one side (its backside end moves down toward the guard); the tite takes the Okie and reduces *both* ends, from the tackles' outside shoulders (5s) to their inside shoulders (4is). That one move inside is the whole front.

Why move the ends *inside*? Look at what the offensive line has to block. With a nose on the center and a 4i in each B gap, the whole interior of the line, from one tackle's inside shoulder to the other's, has a big body in it. Every interior blocker has a defender on him or right beside him. There is no uncovered lineman with a clean path to a linebacker. The offense can still double-team, but every double team is spent on a lineman, and every blocker who stays on a lineman is a blocker who isn't on a linebacker.

Here is the tite doing its job against the most common run in football, inside zone.

⁹J.J. Watt led the NFL with 20.5 sacks in 2012 and was Defensive Player of the Year that season (and in 2014 and 2015): Pro Football Reference, <https://www.pro-football-reference.com/players/W/WattJ.00.htm>; “J. J. Watt,” Wikipedia, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/J._J._Watt. Wade Phillips was Houston's defensive coordinator 2011–2013 and Denver's 2015–2016: “Wade Phillips,” Wikipedia, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Wade_Phillips.

¹⁰“Super Bowl 50,” Wikipedia (February 7, 2016, Levi's Stadium; Denver 24, Carolina 10; Von Miller MVP; Denver “ranked first in the NFL in yards allowed”; Phillips as defensive coordinator): https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Super_Bowl_50. Ware and Miller as Phillips's outside linebackers: “2015 Denver Broncos season,” Wikipedia, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/2015_Denver_Broncos_season.

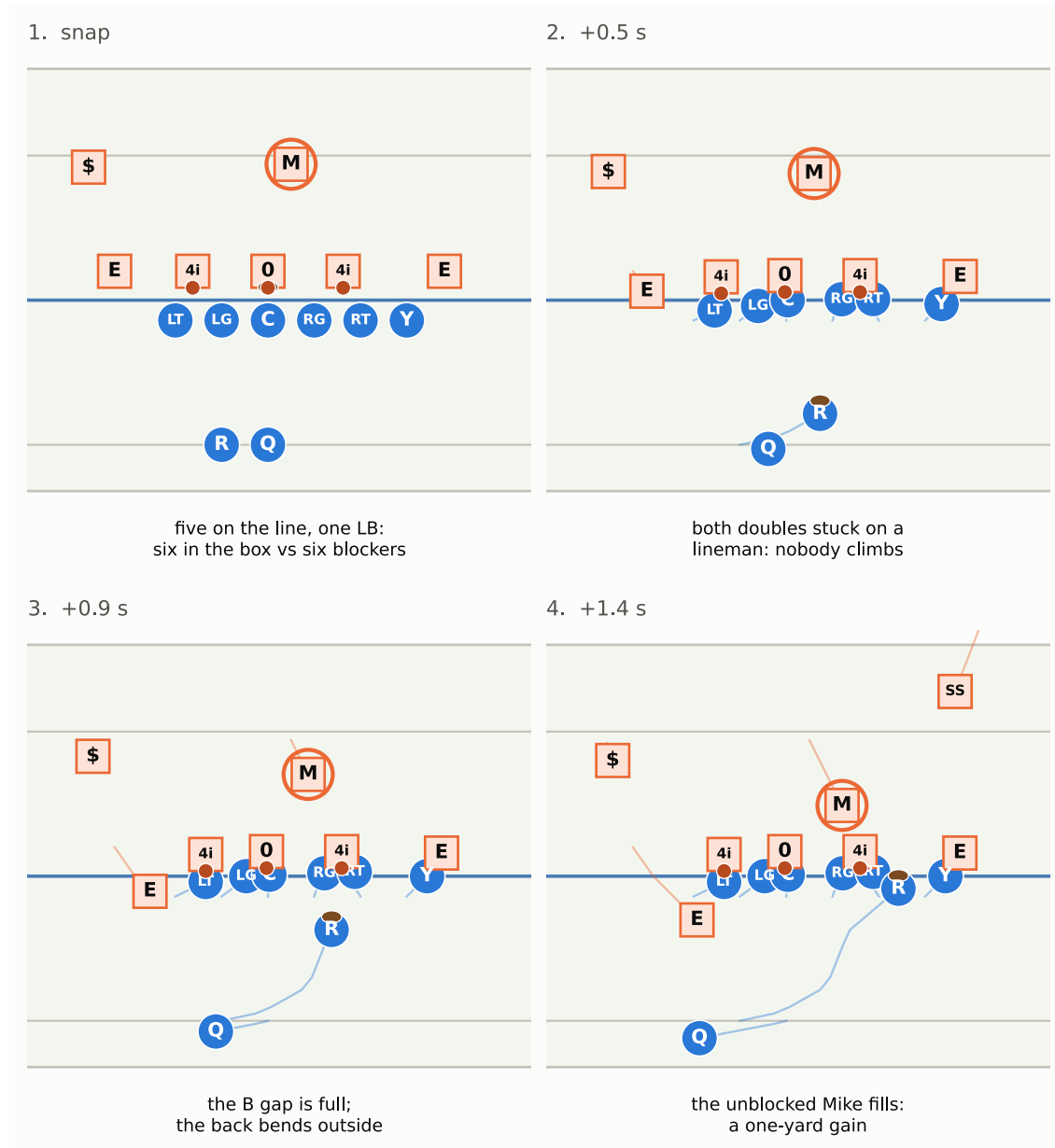


Figure 4: The title front against inside zone right (simulated, in Big Data Bowl tracking coordinates; faint lines are each player's path so far). The offense is a shotgun one-back set with three receivers and an attached tight end (11 personnel), six blockers. The defense is in nickel with a five-man line (dark dots are hands on the ground): a nose (0) and two 4i-techniques with a stand-up edge (E) outside each tackle, one linebacker (M) and a nickel back (\$) outside the box, and two safeties deep. 1: six in the box against six blockers, and the inside linebacker (ringed) has nobody in front of him. 2: the center and left guard double the nose; the right guard and right tackle double the play-side 4i. Neither double moves its man, so neither can send a blocker up to the Mike. 3: the back presses the play-side B gap, his aiming point, and finds it full; he bends outside the tackle. 4: the Mike, never touched, fills and makes the tackle just past the line, a gain of about a yard, with the strong safety arriving from depth.

Walk through Figure 4 with the zone rules from Zone Running in mind. Inside zone wins with double teams: two linemen drive a defensive lineman backward, and when the linebacker behind commits, one of them comes off and blocks him. That requires two things: a lineman the pair can move, and a linebacker within reach. The title takes away both.

- **The doubles can't move their men.** The nose plays the center *and* whichever guard joins the double: the “gap-and-a-half” idea of Fangio’s teaching, in which a big two-gap nose controls one A gap and leans into the other.¹¹ The 4i sits in the B gap, inside the tackle, exactly where inside zone’s aiming point is. The guard can’t reach him and the tackle can’t leave him, because the instant either one does, the 4i is in the hole.

¹¹“Gap and a half” as the Fangio tree’s name for what a two-gap nose does in a light-box front: “Are Jordan Davis and nose tackles a new premium position?”, Philly Cover Corner (May 5, 2022), <https://phillycovercorner.com/2022/05/are-jordan-davis-and-nose-tackles-a-new-premium-position/>.

- **Nobody climbs.** With every blocker spent on a lineman, the one inside linebacker is never touched. He doesn't need to beat a block; he only needs to be right about where the ball ends up, and the wall in front of him has already told the running back where *not* to go.
- **The cutback is plugged.** Inside zone's best friend is the bend back to the weak side. In the title, the backside A and B gaps have the nose and the backside 4i in them, and the backside edge is squeezing down the line behind them. There is nowhere to bend to.

What's left for the runner is the outside: bounce the ball wide, where the play-side edge, a safety coming down and the nickel are waiting. That is the trade the title offers on purpose. **It turns the inside runs that win against two-high defenses into outside runs that its edges and safeties can chase down.**

Why the title exists now: six men, seven gaps

The title has existed in college for a long time, but it took over the NFL conversation in the late 2010s for a reason you have met before: two deep safeties. Defenses facing modern passing offenses want to keep both safeties deep, as long as possible (A First Look at Defense has the numbers: split-safety looks reached a record 42 percent of dropbacks in 2025).¹² Two safeties deep and five defensive backs on the field leaves six men in the box. Against an offense with a tight end attached, that is six defenders for six blockers and seven gaps. By the one-man-per-gap accounting of one-gap football, the numbers don't work.

The title makes them work. One nose who holds both A gaps (or one and a half) is the extra defender the box doesn't have. Five men on the line hold the line of scrimmage, the linebacker runs free, and the safeties can stay home on the pass and fit the run late, from depth. The Fangio tree, Vic Fangio himself and the coaches who worked under him, Brandon Staley among them, built their light-box run defense on exactly that bargain. Fangio's 2018 Chicago Bears, his last season as a coordinator before he became Denver's head coach, are the classic example: big interior linemen (Akiem Hicks and the nose Eddie Goldman), two stand-up edges (Leonard Floyd and Khalil Mack, acquired in a trade the week before the season), and a defense that allowed the fewest points in the league and led it in takeaways.¹³ Staley's 2020 Rams, by one count, played a light box on about 78 percent of snaps, the second-highest rate in the league, and led the NFL in points allowed.¹⁴

What the title gives up

Every front is a trade. The title's costs are specific, and offenses know them.

- **The pass rush.** Three of its five linemen are big interior players built to hold blocks, not beat them; the 4is especially are aligned to take the run away, not to rush. To get four rushers, the title often has to rush both edges and two interior men, or send an off-ball linebacker. Cody Alexander, one of the most widely read writers on defensive structure, names this as the front's main drawback: "its inability to get a rush without sending an off-ball defender."¹⁵
- **The perimeter.** With three big bodies inside the tackles, the defense outside them is thin: one edge on each side, a linebacker flowing from the middle, and safeties coming from depth. Runs that start outside, outside zone, tosses, the jet sweeps of Perimeter and Misdirection, go straight at that thinness.
- **The quick game and the RPO.** A light box with a single linebacker leaves big spaces underneath. The RPO was built for exactly this defender: a lone linebacker who must fill the run will leave the space behind him open for a throw.
- **Rare players, again.** Like the two-gap 3-4, the title needs a nose who can hold two blockers and two 4is with the length to play from an inside shade. The front is only as good as those three men.

¹²NFL Next Gen Stats: split-safety coverage on 42.0% of dropbacks in 2025, the highest since tracking began in 2018: NFL.com, "The coverage that turned the Seahawks into Super Bowl winners and is taking the NFL by storm," <https://www.nfl.com/news/the-coverage-that-turned-the-seahawks-into-super-bowl-winners-and-is-taking-the-nfl-by-storm> (this book's checked facts, planning/FACTS-current.md §10).

¹³"2018 Chicago Bears season," Wikipedia (the Mack trade on September 2, 2018; Hicks and Goldman on the defensive line; a 12-4 record): https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/2018_Chicago_Bears_season. Team defense rankings: Pro Football Reference, <https://www.pro-football-reference.com/years/2018/opp.htm>. Fangio became the Broncos' head coach in January 2019: "Vic Fangio," Wikipedia, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Vic_Fangio.

¹⁴Philly Cover Corner (May 5, 2022): "Staley's Title front with three defensive linemen inside the tackles and five on the line vs. six blockers," and "In 2020 with the Rams, Staley ran a light box 78% of the time, 2nd highest in the league, on way to the league's best defense": <https://phillycovercorner.com/2022/05/are-jordan-davis-and-nose-tackles-a-new-premium-position/>. The 2020 Rams' points allowed: Pro Football Reference, <https://www.pro-football-reference.com/teams/ram/2020.htm>.

¹⁵Cody Alexander, "Flipping the Script," MatchQuarters (August 1, 2022): "With two 4i's and a two-gap Nose, the defense can be over-reliant on off-ball LBs and secondary players rushing the passer," and "one of the main drawbacks of the front is its inability to get a rush without sending an off-ball defender": <https://www.matchquarters.com/p/flipping-the-script>.

Inside zone or outside zone? How a front chooses

The title is the clearest example of a principle that runs through all of defensive front design, and it is the best way to understand why a defense changes fronts from week to week: **every alignment makes some blocks easier and others harder, and a defense picks the alignment that makes the offense's favourite blocks hard.**

Recall the two zone plays from Zone Running:

- **Inside zone** is won by *double teams* that move a defensive lineman back and then *climb* to a linebacker. Its aiming point is the play-side B gap.
- **Outside zone** is won by *reach blocks*: each blocker steps sideways and tries to get his head outside the defender in front of him. Its aiming point is the tight end's outside leg, and its biggest gains come from the edge being reached (the bounce) or the defense over-running the play (the cutback).

Now ask what kind of alignment makes each one hard.

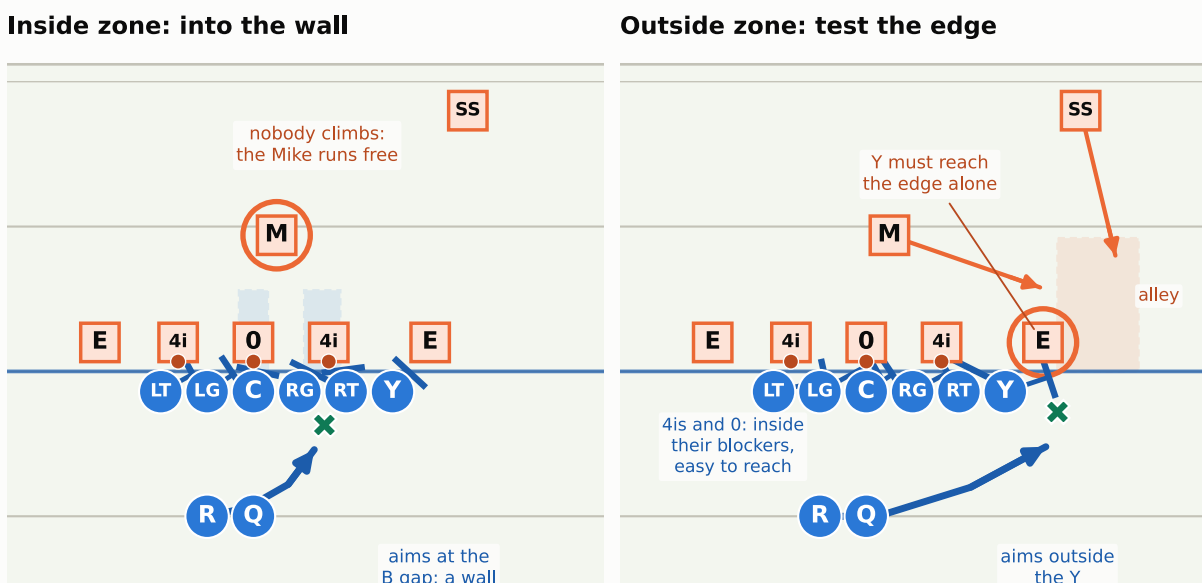


Figure 5: The same tite front against the two zone runs, first steps only (illustrative). Left, inside zone: the run aims at the play-side B gap (green X), right where the 4i stands, and the three interior linemen (dark dots) occupy all five offensive linemen, so the doubles have nobody to climb to and the one linebacker (ringed) runs free. The shaded lanes are where the back wanted to go: both full. Right, outside zone: the run aims outside the tight end (green X). The 4is and the nose are *inside* the blockers who must reach them, the easiest kind of reach, so the line can get its heads across; the whole play rests on the play-side edge (ringed, E), whom the tight end must reach alone, and on the linebacker and the strong safety (SS) getting outside fast enough to fill the alley (shaded) if the edge is reached. The tite takes the middle away and asks its edges to win.

The rule of thumb that falls out of Figure 5 is simple to state:

- **To beat the double team, line up on top of or just inside the blockers.** A nose on the center and 4is inside the tackles make every interior lineman covered; the pairs that try to double them can't move them and can't leave them. That is the tite's answer to inside zone, power, duo and the other downhill runs.
- **To beat the reach, line up outside the blockers.** A reach block is hardest when the defender is already a step to the play side of the blocker: a 3-technique outside the guard, a 5 outside the tackle, a 9 or a wide edge outside the tight end. That is why the classic answer to an outside-zone team is a *wider* front, with shades outside the blockers, often a four-man even front with a 3-technique who can penetrate before the guard's reach lands, as in Defensive Line Play's one-gap animation.

The two answers pull in opposite directions, which is why no front stops everything. A tite that lines up inside its blockers to choke inside zone is lined up exactly where outside zone's reaches are easiest; a wide four-man front that beats the reach leaves the interior gaps to linebackers who can be climbed to. Defenses solve the dilemma in three ways, and you can watch for all of them:

1. **Change the front by opponent.** A defense facing an inside-zone, gap-scheme team plays a lot of tite; the same defense facing a wide-zone team widens its edges and plays more four-man fronts. Fangio's own defenses varied in exactly this way: Alexander

notes that in Denver Fangio favoured a four-down front more often than his former assistant Staley, who preferred the five-man front.¹⁶

2. **Change the front by down, distance and formation.** Tite on first-and-10 against two tight ends, four-man front on second-and-long against three receivers.
3. **Change the front after the offense lines up.** Shift from one to the other at the last moment, so the offense's blocking calls are made against the wrong picture. That is the last section of this chapter.

Who, in either front, makes the tackle on the run that gets through? That is the job of the run fits, the full eleven-man accounting of who owns which gap and who forces the ball back inside, in Run Fits and Box Math.

Nickel fronts: 4-2-5, 3-3-5, 2-4-5

Everything so far has been about base defenses. But the modern NFL plays nickel, five defensive backs, on most snaps: about 60 percent of all runs and passes in 2025, with base (four defensive backs) on about 30 percent and dime on most of the rest.¹⁷ So the front you will see most often on Sunday is a nickel front, and nickel fronts have their own three-number names. All three end in 5: five defensive backs. The first two numbers split the other six players between the line and the linebackers.

4-2-5: the default

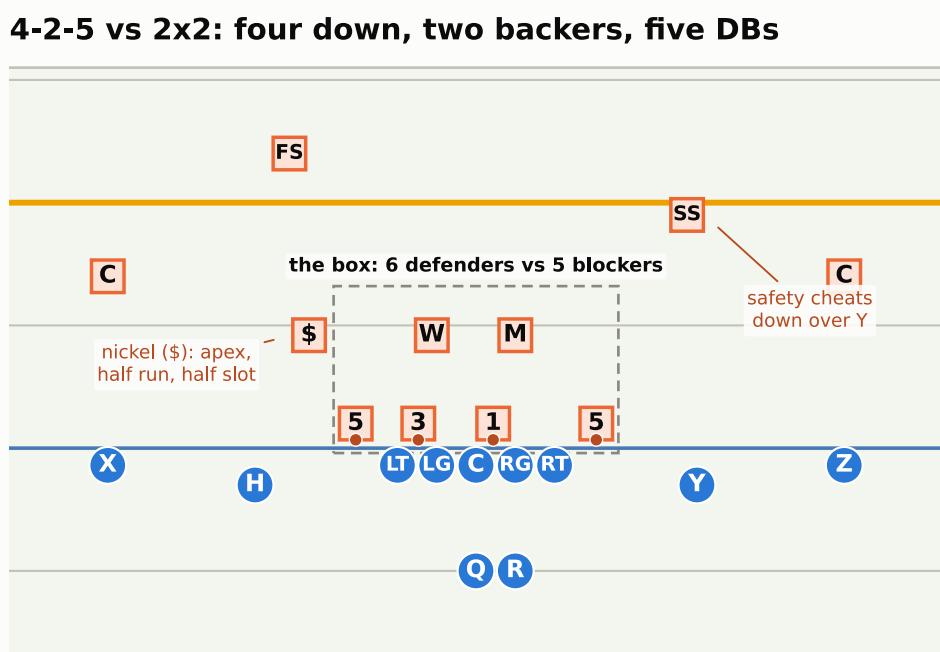


Figure 6: The 4-2-5 against a shotgun 2x2 (two receivers on each side, 11 personnel with the tight end, Y, flexed out as a slot receiver on the right). Four hands down: two ends in wide 5-techniques and two tackles, a 3 and a 1 (this is the four-man even front of Even Fronts). Two linebackers (M and W) in the box. Five defensive backs: corners (C) on the outside receivers, the nickel back (\$) in the apex between the left tackle and the slot receiver H, and two safeties deep, the right one cheated down over Y. With no tight end attached the offense has five blockers, and the box (dashed) holds six defenders: four linemen and two linebackers.

The 4-2-5 is the even front with a linebacker swapped for a nickel back: four down linemen, two linebackers, five defensive backs. It is the most natural answer to three receivers, because it changes as little as possible. The four-man line is the same one the defense plays in base, so the linemen's rules don't change; the two linebackers who stay on are the Mike and the Will, the better athletes; and the nickel back takes the slot receiver the Sam would have been chasing.

Count the box in Figure 6 and you will see why it holds up against the run as well as it does. With the tight end split out, the offense has five blockers; the 4-2-5 has six in the box. One more defender than blockers is the plus-one idea of Run Fits and Box

¹⁶Alexander, "Flipping the Script" (as above): Fangio used his four-down front more often in Denver, while Staley preferred the five-man front: <https://www.matchquarters.com/p/flipping-the-script>.

¹⁷Author's calculation from the nflverse participation file (FTN charting) joined to play-by-play, regular-season 2025 run and pass plays with personnel recorded, via [nfl-readpy](https://github.com/nfl-readpy) (the code is in this chapter's nickel-labels figure). It agrees with NFL Next Gen Stats' 29.7% base-defense rate for 2025: NFL.com, "NFL trend watch: heavy personnel could shape Super Bowl LX showdown between Patriots and Seahawks," <https://www.nfl.com/news/nfl-trend-watch-heavy-personnel-could-shape-super-bowl-lx-showdown-between-patriots-and-seahawks>.

Math, and the nickel at the apex makes a seventh who can fill late. The offense’s usual answers are to bring the tight end back in tight (six blockers), or to read an unblocked defender with the quarterback, the option principle, which turns the quarterback into the extra man.

2-4-5: the 3-4 team’s nickel

Here is the front from the chapter’s opening.

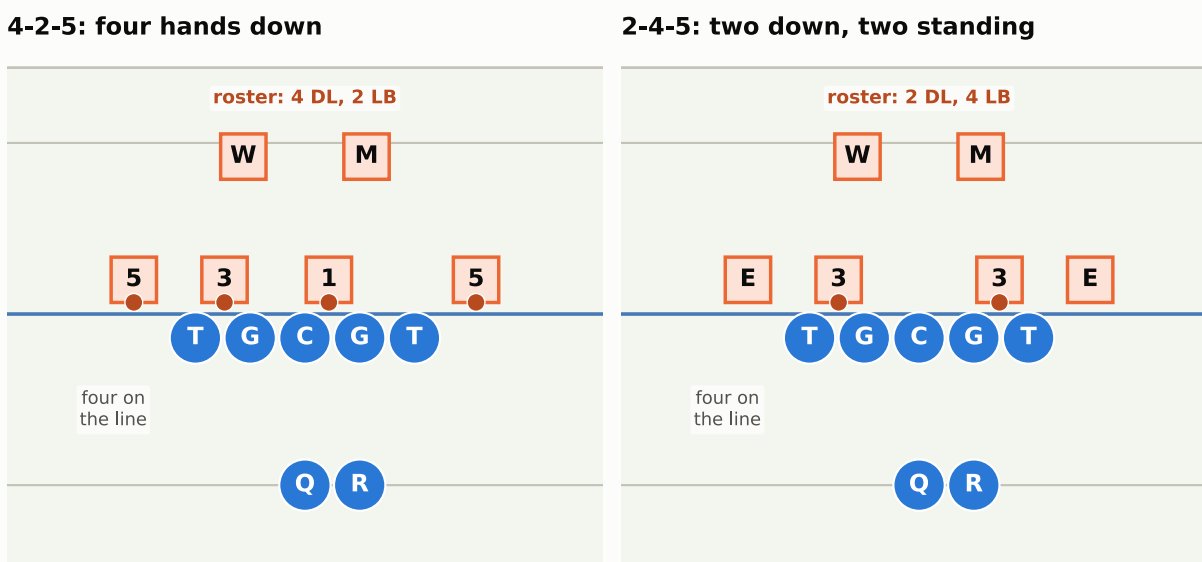


Figure 7: Two nickel fronts, one picture. Left, a 4-2-5: four defensive linemen, two of them defensive ends with their hands down at the edges. Right, a 2-4-5, the usual nickel of a 3-4 team: the nose has come off the field, the two remaining linemen play the tackle spots (here both 3-techniques, outside the guards), and the two outside linebackers stand up on the edges (E, no dot). Same alignments, same two linebackers behind them, same five defensive backs (not shown); on the field both are four-man lines. Only the stances, and the roster, differ.

The 2-4-5 is what a 3-4 team usually plays when the offense brings out a third receiver: the nose tackle comes off for a nickel back, the two ends slide inside to play the tackle spots, and the two outside linebackers stay on the edges, standing. You met it as a footnote in *A First Look at Defense*; look at it now in Figure 7, next to a 4-2-5, and the two are the same front. Four players on the line, two linebackers behind them, five defensive backs. If the 2-4-5’s outside linebackers put their hands down, you couldn’t tell them apart at all.

So why the different name? Because the name is built from the *roster*, not the picture. The 2-4-5’s edges are listed as linebackers because, in the team’s base defense, they are the 3-4’s outside linebackers. Bring the same two players onto a 4-3 team and they would be listed as defensive ends, and the identical alignment would be called a 4-2-5.

3-3-5: two meanings

The 3-3-5 has three down linemen, three linebackers and five defensive backs, and in practice it comes in two quite different shapes.

- **In the NFL, the 3-3-5 is usually a five-man line in nickel.** Three linemen inside, a stand-up edge on each end, and one linebacker behind them: the title front of Figure 4 is exactly this. It is the light-box run front of the Fangio tree, with three big bodies taking up five blockers and the safeties staying deep.
- **In college, “3-3-5” usually means the 3-3-5 stack,** a different defense with three linemen and three linebackers stacked directly behind them, built in the 1990s to put more speed on the field against spread offenses. It belongs to The College Laboratory.

And in the data, as the next figure shows, “3-3-5” often means neither: a four-man line with one edge listed as a defensive end and the other as a linebacker.

The labels, measured

You can see how loosely these names attach to the football in the play-by-play data. Since 2023, the nflverse participation file (charted by FTN) lists the roster position of every defender on every snap, so each snap’s personnel can be counted as linemen–linebackers–defensive backs. Here is every 2025 nickel snap, split by what the roster labels call it.

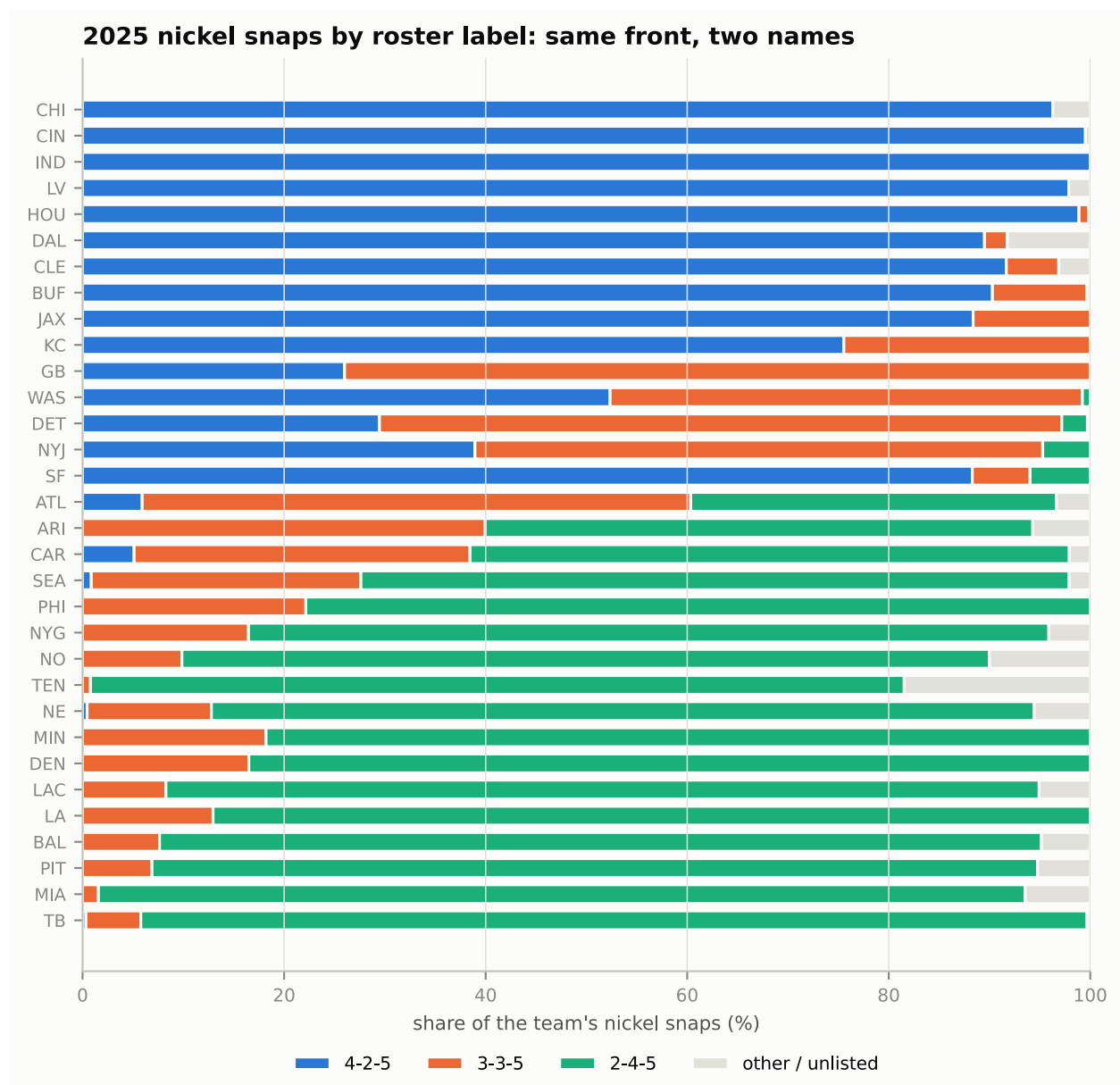


Figure 8: What each team's nickel snaps are called, if you count roster positions: 2025 regular season, every run and pass play with five defensive backs, by defense. Blue: four defensive linemen and two linebackers (4-2-5). Orange: three and three (3-3-5). Green: two and four (2-4-5). The league splits into two camps that line up almost identically on the field: teams whose edge rushers are listed as defensive ends (mostly 4-2-5, top) and teams whose edge rushers are listed as outside linebackers (mostly 2-4-5, bottom), with a few in between whose two edges carry one label each (3-3-5). The table below the chart shows that the three labels have the same box count and the same pass rush. Data: nflverse participation (FTN charting) joined to play-by-play via nflreadpy; positions are as FTN lists them, which follows team rosters.

roster label	share of nickel snaps	avg. defenders in the box	avg. pass rushers	four-man rushes
4-2-5	37%	6.1	4.3	75%
3-3-5	18%	6.0	4.3	69%
2-4-5	41%	6.0	4.3	75%

Two things jump out of Figure 8 and the table under it. First, the league splits cleanly into two camps, and the split has nothing to do with what the defenses do: it is about how teams list their edge rushers. Teams whose edges are “defensive ends” play the 4-2-5; teams whose edges are “outside linebackers” play the 2-4-5. Second, the three labels describe nearly identical football. All

three put about six defenders in the box, all three rush about four on passes, three times in four exactly four. The numbers on the graphic come from a roster sheet. The front comes from the alignment.

That is why this book, and every coach you will read, asks you to **count hands, not names**. Before the snap, count the players with a hand on the ground and the players standing at the ends of the line, and note where the man nearest the center is. Four down is a four-man line, whatever the graphic says. Two down with two standing edges is a four-man line too, built from 3-4 personnel. Three down inside the tackles with an edge on each side is a tite, five on the line. The personnel label tells you which players are on the field, which matters for what they *can* do (a 3-4 outside linebacker can drop into coverage more comfortably than a 4-3 end); the alignment tells you what they are *about* to do.

Multiple defenses: one personnel group, many fronts

If the label is personnel and the front is alignment, nothing stops a defense from playing several fronts with the same eleven players. Almost every NFL defense now does. A **multiple defense** (also called a **hybrid defense**) lines up in more than one front family, odd and even, four-man and five-man, often from the same personnel and sometimes switching between them before the snap. “Now every team is ‘multiple,’” one analyst wrote more than a decade ago, and it has only become more true.¹⁸

Belichick’s Patriots were the model of the idea: a defense that might be a two-gap 3-4 one week and a four-man front the next, built to take away whatever the opponent did best. The modern versions go further, changing fronts *within* a series, and the most effective way to do it is a shift: show the offense one front, then move into another as the quarterback is calling the protection.

¹⁸Jene Bramel, Footballguys (March 5, 2014): “Now every team is ‘multiple’”: https://www.footballguys.com/article/14bramel_rtd_idp_coaching_changes. The Patriots’ week-to-week changes of front: Chris B. Brown, “Ode to the War Daddies,” Grantland (February 6, 2012), <https://grantland.com/features/bill-belichick-vince-wilfork-new-england-patriots-defense/>.

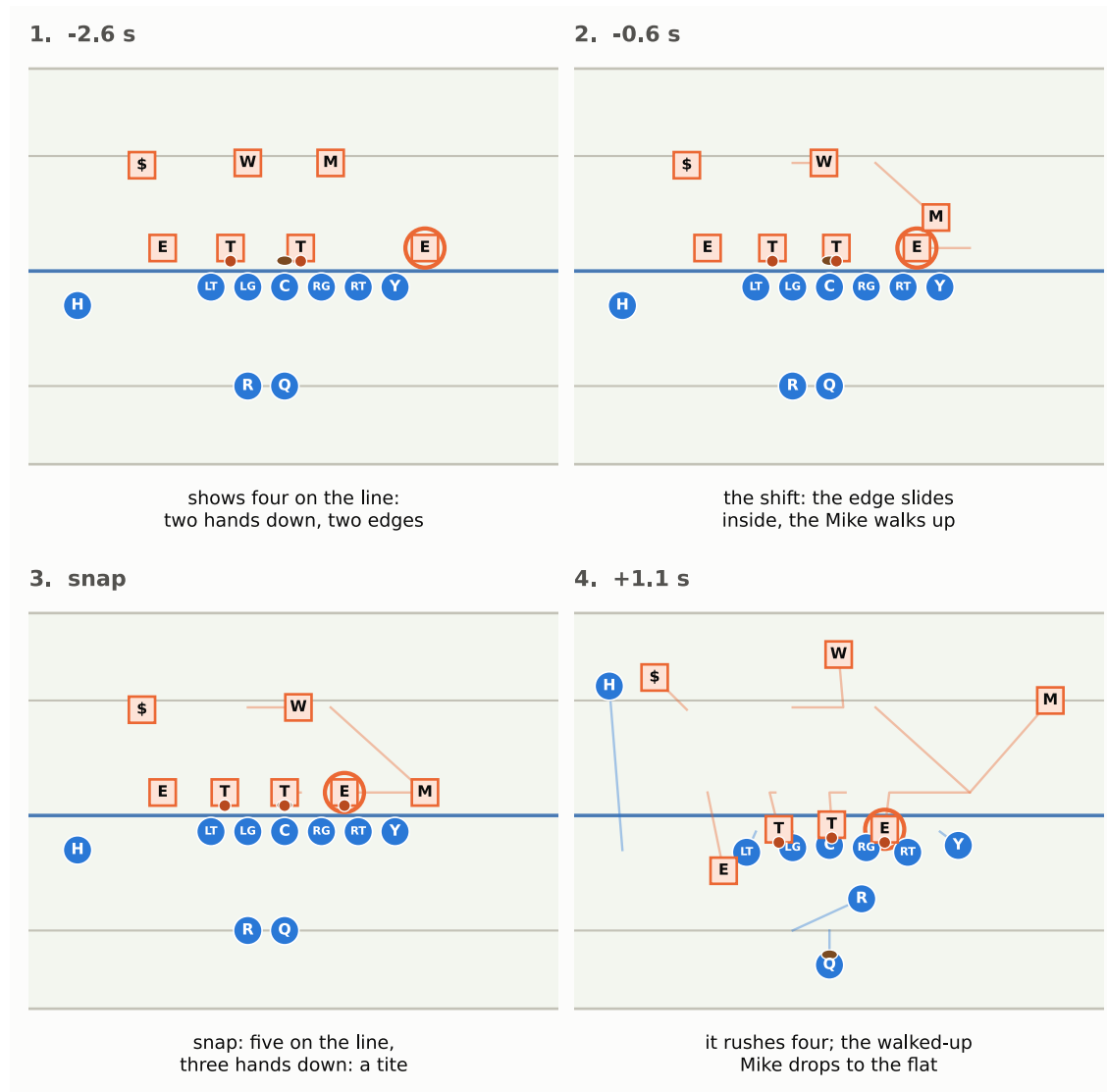


Figure 9: Same eleven players, two fronts (simulated; dark dots are hands on the ground). The defense is a 3-4 team's nickel (2-4-5 personnel) against a shotgun one-back set with the tight end (Y) attached on the right. 1: it shows a four-man even front: two tackles (T) with their hands down, a 3 and a 1, and two stand-up edges (E), the Mike and Will behind them. 2: as the quarterback calls his protection, the front shifts. The right edge (ringed) slides inside to the tackle's inside shoulder, the 1 moves onto the center and the left 3 slides out to a 4i. 3: at the snap the right edge has his hand on the ground as a 4i; the Mike has walked up outside the tight end as the new edge: five on the line, three hands down, a tite. 4: the offense passes. Four rush, and the walked-up Mike drops into the flat: a front that showed five on the line rushed four, and the player who looked like a rusher is in coverage.

Why go to that trouble? Because, as Zone Running explained, an offensive line decides its blocking before the snap: who is covered, who doubles, who climbs, and, on a pass, which way the center slides and who picks up which rusher. A front that shifts at the last moment makes those decisions against the wrong picture. In Figure 9 the line set its rules against a four-man even front with two linebackers; at the snap it faced a five-man line with one, and on the pass, the player it had counted as a rusher (the walked-up Mike) was in coverage. Georgia's defense under Kirby Smart is known for doing exactly this, moving from a 4-2-5 into its mint front before the snap, without a substitution, by sliding a lineman inside to a 4i and standing up an end on the short side.¹⁹

The cost of being multiple is complexity. Every front has its own gap assignments and its own fits, and every player has to know all of them; a shift that is a beat late leaves a gap empty at the snap. That is why multiple defenses are built around smart, versatile players (edges who can rush and drop, linemen who can play a 3 and a 4i) and why they live and die on the communication of the green-dot linebacker who relays the call.

¹⁹Georgia's mint front and its pre-snap move from a 4-2-5 ("The RDT becomes the nose and the RDE slips into a 4i. The boundary end stands up and walks. The other DT becomes a 4i"): Coach Kou, "Georgia 3-4 Mint Front: Games and Pressures," Coach Kou's Substack (July 8, 2025), <https://coachkoufootball.substack.com/p/georgia-3-4-mint-front-games-pressures>.

Dialect: Okie, Eagle, G, and the problem with names

You now know what the fronts *are*. A word about what they are *called*, because front names are the least standardized vocabulary in football. Every staff has a language, inherited from the coaches who trained its coaches, and the same word can mean different things in neighbouring buildings. Two names you will hear are good examples.

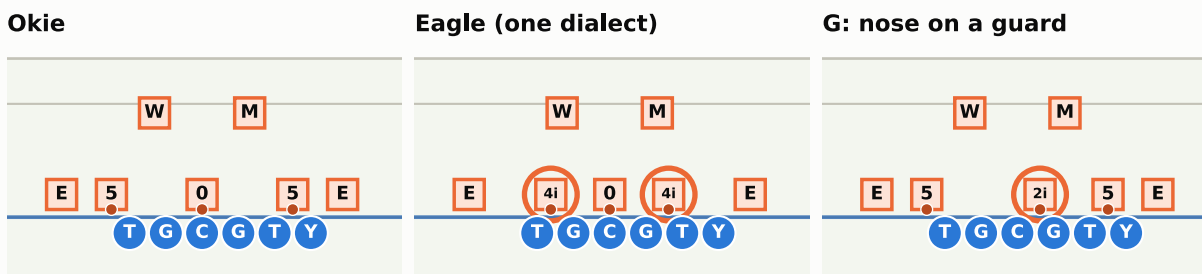


Figure 10: Dialect, drawn against the Okie (left). Middle, the Eagle front as many modern 3-4 playbooks use the word: the ends pinch from the tackles' outside shoulders (5s) to their inside shoulders (4is), which is the same picture Fangio's staffs call tite and Kirby Smart's Georgia calls mint. Right, a G front: one letter in the call moves one man, the nose, off the center onto the guard's inside shoulder (a 2i, G for guard), here toward the tight end. Everyone else is where the Okie put him. Dark dots are hands on the ground; the ringed players are the ones who moved.

The Eagle front has meant at least three things. In the 1940s it was Greasy Neale's five-man line, the Philadelphia Eagles' defense and the 3-4's ancestor. In the late 1980s Fritz Shurmur, the Los Angeles Rams' defensive coordinator, built a linebacker-heavy package he called the Eagle, and later wrote a coaching book on it, *The Eagle Five Linebacker Defense* (1993); in the Rams' 21-7 playoff win over Philadelphia after the 1989 season, his defense dropped into zone coverage on almost every snap and, by his own account, never blitzed.²⁰ And in many modern 3-4 playbooks, "Eagle" is the Okie with its ends pinched inside to 4is: the middle panel of Figure 10, the same alignment other staffs call tite or mint.²¹ Three meanings, one word, and only context tells you which.

The G front is a tag rather than a whole front: it moves the nose from the center (or from his shade on the center, in a four-man front) onto a guard's inside shoulder, a 2i. "G" is for guard. It is a small move with a specific purpose: it forces the center to step sideways to block the nose, which slows down the center-guard double team on inside zone and gives the linebacker behind the nose a cleaner path. You'll most often see the G tag on four-man Over and Under fronts, where it moves a 1-technique to a 2i; the right panel of Figure 10 applies the same idea to the Okie.²²

The point is not to memorize every staff's dictionary. It is to read the *alignment* first and attach the name second. If an analyst says "Eagle" and you see 4is inside the tackles, you know what he means even if his playbook and yours disagree.

i Madden vs. real life

In Madden, the defensive playbook is a menu of named fronts: pick "3-4 Odd" or "Nickel 3-3-5 Wide" and the players run to their spots. Real defenses don't call a front from a menu so much as build it from rules. The call names a front, a tag or two (a G, a slant, who is the edge), and a coverage, and each player's alignment then depends on where the offense puts its tight end and its back, which side is the wide side of the field, and whether the offense shifts. Two teams can call the same word and line up differently, and the same team can call two different words and end up in the same alignment. The names are shorthand for a set of instructions, and every staff writes its own.

²⁰"Fritz Shurmur," Wikipedia (Rams defensive coordinator 1982-1990; author of *The Eagle Five Linebacker Defense*, 1993): https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Fritz_Shurmur. The 1989 NFC wild-card game (Rams 21, Eagles 7) and Shurmur's all-zone, no-blitz plan: UPI, "Analysis" (December 31, 1989), <https://www.upi.com/Archives/1989/12/31/Analysis/1604631083600/>.

²¹For one modern definition (the ends "align themselves slightly further inside on the shoulders of the offensive tackles... only responsible for one gap"), Trevor Sikkema, Pewter Report (May 16, 2017), <https://www.pewterreport.com/cover-3-4-3-vs-3-4-versatile-can-bucs-defense/2/>. Names vary by staff.

²²Chris Haddad, "The Over Front Install Guide," Vqictory Sports (updated April 9, 2026): in the G front, "the Nose tackle moves from a 1-technique to a 2i (inside shoulder of the guard)," which makes the center work laterally and slows combo blocks on inside zone: <https://www.viqtorysports.com/the-over-front-in-football-explained/>.

Film room

i Film room: Houston Texans 2011–2012

The scheme: Wade Phillips's one-gap 3-4, in his first two seasons as the Texans' defensive coordinator. The 2011 team's preview called it "his one-gap scheme," and in 2012 its 5-technique end, J.J. Watt, led the NFL with 20.5 sacks and was Defensive Player of the Year.

What to notice:

- The ends' alignment and first step. Watt lines up on a tackle's outside shoulder, like an Okie end, and then attacks the gap at the snap instead of controlling the man. Count how often his first step is across the line.
- What the outside linebackers do. On most passing downs, both are rushing; Phillips's 3-4 rushed four like any four-man front.
- How often the "3-4" looks like an Under front with a linebacker standing up. That is the one-gap 3-4 of Figure 3 in its natural habitat.

i Film room: Denver Broncos, Super Bowl 50 (2015 season)

The game: Super Bowl 50, February 7, 2016, at Levi's Stadium: Denver 24, Carolina 10. Phillips, now Denver's coordinator, had the league's top defense by yards allowed, and in the Super Bowl his two stand-up edges, Von Miller and DeMarcus Ware, chased the league MVP, Cam Newton, all night. Miller was the game's MVP, with 2.5 sacks and two forced fumbles; Malik Jackson fell on the first in the end zone for Denver's first touchdown.²³

What to notice: the edges. Before each snap, find Miller and Ware: standing, wide, often on different sides from snap to snap. Watch whether they rush or drop (mostly rush), how they win around the tackles with speed, and how, on Newton's scrambles and designed runs, they keep contain rather than racing past him. The stand-up edge as a weapon is this game.

i Film room: Philadelphia Eagles 2024

The season: Vic Fangio's first year as the Eagles' defensive coordinator. The defense allowed the fewest yards in the NFL, about 278 a game, and the season ended with a 40–22 Super Bowl LIX win in which the Eagles pressured Patrick Mahomes with four-man rushes.²⁴ Its five-man front was the title of this chapter, with Jordan Davis, a 341-pound nose at his combine, between two 4is, usually Jalen Carter and Milton Williams, and two edges outside them.²⁵

What to notice:

- Count the hands down on early downs. Three inside the tackles, with an edge on each side, is the title.
- Watch Davis against a double team on an inside run: does the pair move him? Then find the linebacker behind him and see whether a blocker ever reaches him.
- Watch the safeties on those runs. They start deep, often 12 yards or more, and arrive late but fast. That is the light-box bargain: the front holds the line so the safeties can stay home on the pass.

²³Miller's 2.5 sacks and two forced fumbles in Super Bowl 50, the first recovered by Malik Jackson in the end zone for Denver's first touchdown: "Super Bowl 50," Wikipedia, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Super_Bowl_50; "Von Miller," Wikipedia, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Von_Miller.

²⁴The 2024 Eagles allowed 4,732 yards (278.4 per game), the fewest in the NFL: Pro Football Reference, <https://www.pro-football-reference.com/teams/phi/2024.htm>. Super Bowl LIX (February 9, 2025): Eagles 40, Chiefs 22, with the Eagles' pressure coming from four-man rushes: this book's checked facts (planning/FACTS-current.md §1) and "Super Bowl LIX," Wikipedia, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Super_Bowl_LIX.

²⁵John McMullen, "Eagles 2024 training camp preview: interior defensive line," SI.com Eagles Today (July 15, 2024): "Carter will mainly play 4i and 3-technique in Fangio's variable fronts while Davis will handle the nose/shade," and "the five-man (50) includes two overhang players outside two 4i techniques who bookend nose tackle Jordan Davis," with Milton Williams at the other 4i: <https://www.si.com/nfl/eagles/onsi/news/eagles-2024-training-camp-preview-interior-defensive-line-01j2vh9mv12p>. Davis's combine weight (341 pounds, 2022): nflverse combine file, as in Defensive Line Play.

The season: Kirby Smart's Georgia defense, which many observers rank among the best in college football history, won the national championship, beating Alabama 33–18.²⁶ Its front featured two interior linemen the Eagles later drafted in the first round, Jordan Davis and Jalen Carter, so the 2021 Bulldogs and the 2024 Eagles are, in a sense, the same front four years apart.

What to notice: the pre-snap movement. Georgia often lines up in a four-man front and shifts into its mint front, a tackle sliding inside to a 4i and a defensive end standing up, as the offense calls its plays. Watch the offensive line's heads turn as the front changes, and then where the run goes.

Watch for it on Sunday

💡 Watch for it

Before the snap: count the hands, find the center.

- Is anybody head-up on the center? A nose over the ball means an odd front; nobody there means an even one.
- Count the hands on the ground. Four is a four-man line, whatever the graphic says. Two down plus two standing edges is also a four-man line, usually a 3-4 team's 2-4-5 nickel. Three inside the tackles plus a standing edge on each side is a five-man tite (or mint) front.
- Who is standing on the edges? A standing edge is a rusher who might drop; note his number and watch him on passes.
- Where are the ends: outside the tackles (5s, built to beat the reach and set the edge), head-up (4s, two-gappers) or inside them (4is, a tite, built to choke inside runs)?

At the snap: the first step and the count.

- Did the front change in the last seconds? A shift (an edge sliding inside, a linebacker walking up) means the defense is trying to beat the offensive line's blocking calls.
- Do the ends step into the tackles' chests (two-gap) or into the gaps (one-gap)?
- On a pass, how many rushed, and who? Five on the line rushing four means somebody standing at the line dropped.

After the play: where did the run go?

- Against a tite, did the inside run get through, or did it bounce outside? If it bounced, who made the tackle: an edge, the linebacker, or a safety?
- Did the offense's play fit the front? Inside zone into a tite is a fight on the defense's terms; outside zone and perimeter runs test its edges.

For your prediction log (How to Watch a Broadcast): on first and second down, write down the number of hands on the ground and whether the front was odd or even, then whether the run went inside or outside. After a quarter you'll know which front the defense uses to stop what, and whether the offense noticed.

²⁶The 2021 season (national championship win over Alabama, 33–18; "one of the greatest defenses in college football history"; Jordan Davis and Jalen Carter on the roster): "2021 Georgia Bulldogs football team," Wikipedia, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/2021_Georgia_Bulldogs_football_team. The Eagles drafted Davis (13th overall, 2022) and Carter (9th overall, 2023): "Jordan Davis (defensive lineman)," Wikipedia, [https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Jordan_Davis_\(defensive_lineman\)](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Jordan_Davis_(defensive_lineman)); "Jalen Carter," Wikipedia, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Jalen_Carter.

Predict the play

💡 Predict the play

Drill 1. Name it, then pick a run. First-and-10 from the offense's own 35. The offense is in the shotgun with three receivers and an attached tight end (Y). The defense is in nickel. Name the front. How many defenders are in the box, and how many blockers does the offense have? If you were calling the run, would you run inside zone, or something else?

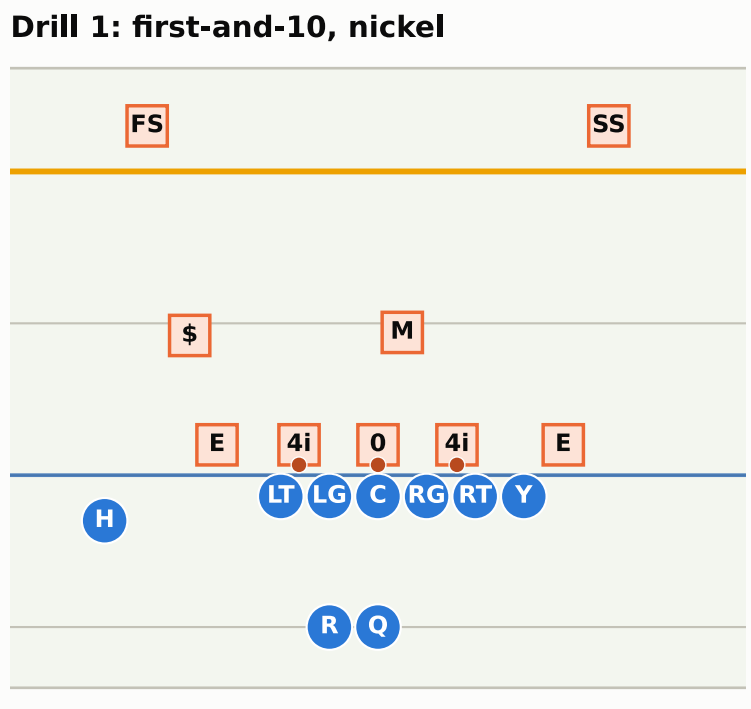


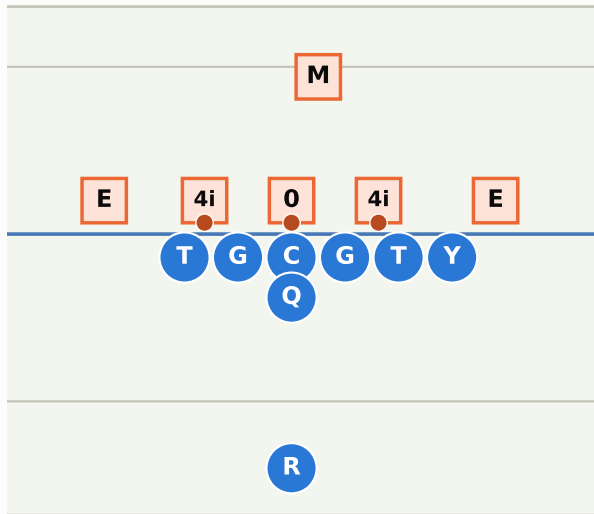
Figure 11: Drill 1: the defense's alignment before the snap (dark dots are hands on the ground). Two safeties deep, a nickel (\$) over the slot on the left, and the corners on the wide receivers (outside the picture).

Answer 1 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

💡 Predict the play

Drill 2. Choose your front. You coordinate the defense. This week's opponent runs outside zone more than any other play, from tight formations with the quarterback under center, and its tight end is an excellent blocker. Here are two fronts you could show on first down. Which would you rather be in, and where will the run most likely go against each?

Front A: tite



Front B: wide four-man

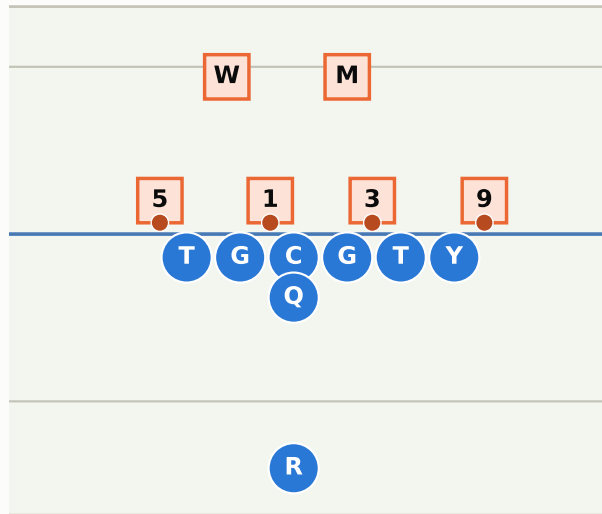


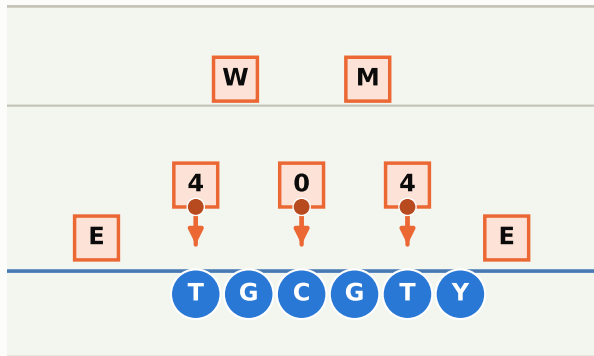
Figure 12: Drill 2: two fronts against the same under-center, one-tight-end formation. Front A: the tite: a 0 and two 4is between two stand-up edges, the right edge on the tight end's outside shoulder (a 9), one linebacker. Front B: a four-man even front aligned wide: a 3-technique on the right guard's outside shoulder, a 1 on the center, a 5 on the left tackle and a defensive end (9) on the tight end, with two linebackers.

Answer 2 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

💡 Predict the play

Drill 3. Which 3-4 is it? Two snaps from the same 3-4 defense against the same formation. The pictures show the first step of each lineman (orange arrows), a quarter-second after the snap. For each snap, say whether the front is playing two-gap or one-gap, and which linebackers you expect to be free.

Snap A



Snap B

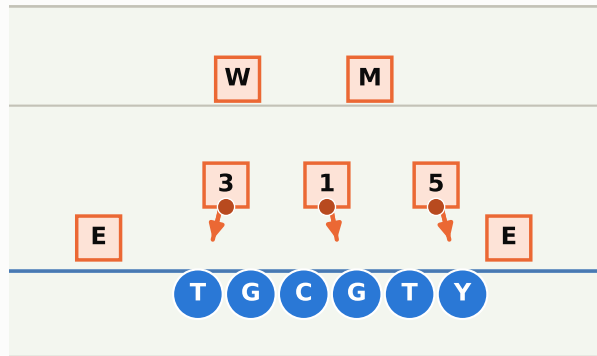


Figure 13: Drill 3: two snaps, one quarter-second after the snap (linemen drawn a little deeper than real so their first steps show; dark dots are hands on the ground). Snap A: a nose head-up on the center and ends head-up on the tackles, each stepping straight into the blocker in front of him. Snap B: the nose shaded toward the tight end and the ends on the outside shoulders of the guard and the tackle, each stepping into the gap beside his blocker.

Answer 3 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

Back to the broadcast

The chapter opened with a graphic that said 3-4 and a picture that kept changing. Now you can read both.

- *The graphic says 3-4, and you count four on the line, two standing:* that is the 3-4 team's **2-4-5 nickel**, its nose on the bench and its two outside linebackers on the edges. The roster says 2-4-5; the football is a four-man line. Count hands, not names.
- *Next snap, five across the line, three of them enormous and wedged inside the tackles, one linebacker behind them:* a **tite**, built from the same personnel by sliding an edge inside and standing up another player at the end of the line. A **multiple** defense, changing fronts without substituting.
- *The inside run into a wall, the linebacker never touched:* the tite's whole purpose. A nose and two 4is occupy all five offensive linemen, the doubles can't climb, and the one linebacker makes the tackle. That is how six defenders stop a run aimed at six blockers: one of them, the nose, is doing the work of two.

Takeaways

- **Find the center.** A defender head-up on the center makes the front odd; nobody there makes it even. The odd fronts are built around a heavy nose who takes two blockers so somebody else can run free.
- **The 3-4 Okie is one alignment played two ways.** Two-gap (head-up, control and read) keeps the inside linebackers clean at the cost of rare bodies and little pass rush; one-gap (shaded, attack) turns the 3-4 into an aggressive front, often an Under with a standing Sam. The first step tells you which.
- **The stand-up edge is the 3-4's great legacy.** Standing gives him vision, width and the option to drop, which makes the defense's rush uncertain; the price is leverage against the run.
- **The tite walls off the middle.** A 0 and two 4is cover every interior blocker, so inside zone's double teams can neither move them nor climb, and a light box with two safeties deep can still stop inside runs. It gives up pass rush, the perimeter and the space underneath.
- **Fronts choose what to stop.** Line up on or inside blockers to beat double teams (inside runs); line up outside them to beat reaches (outside zone). No front does both, so defenses change fronts by opponent, by situation and by shifting at the snap.
- **Nickel labels are roster labels.** 4-2-5, 2-4-5 and most NFL 3-3-5s describe nearly the same box count and pass rush; what differs is whether the edges are listed as ends or linebackers. Count hands, not names, and read alignment before dialect.

Connections

Builds on: Defensive Line Play (techniques, one-gap and two-gap, the edge) and Even Fronts (the four-man fronts and their strength rules), with A First Look at Defense (base, nickel, the box) and Zone Running (inside and outside zone) as the background.

Sets up:

- Linebackers and the Second Level: the players these fronts are built to keep clean, and what they do with the freedom.
- Run Fits and Box Math: the full eleven-man accounting behind every front in this chapter, the plus-one, and how two-high light-box defenses fit the run.
- The Pass Rush and Zone Blitz and Simulated Pressure: the stand-up edge's other job, and how standing edges and five-man lines become four-man rushes from unexpected places.
- History: Arnsperger's 53 in The 1978 Liberation, and the 3-4's revival and the hybrid edge in Dynasties and Counterpunches.

See also (case study): Fangio's Two-High Revolution and Macdonald's Answer, the tite front and the light box as the run-defense half of the two-high era.

If you want to go deeper: Cody Alexander's *MatchQuarters* site and books (defensive structure, including the tite and four-down fronts, from a coach's view); Chris B. Brown's *The Art of Smart Football* and his Grantland and Smart Football writing on the 3-4 and its noses; and the 2024 Eagles' or 2021 Georgia Bulldogs' games, watched for nothing but the three men inside the tackles.

i Go deeper

Measuring the wall. The tite's promise is that nobody climbs: every offensive lineman is still engaged with a defensive lineman a second after the snap, so the linebacker behind them is untouched. Tracking data can test that. In the simulated tite play above, here is the distance from the Mike to the nearest offensive lineman at three moments, computed from its Big Data Bowl-format frames (simulated, BDB-format):

defender	+0.5 s	+1.0 s	+1.4 s
Mike, tite vs inside zone (simulated)	4.4 yd	3.2 yd	2.3 yd

On real frames the same measure, computed for every inside linebacker on every run, separates fronts that keep linebackers clean from fronts that don't. The 2025 Big Data Bowl release (2022 season, weeks 1–9) has tracking for every player and a players file with positions; pair it with the nflverse participation data above to tag each snap's front. The data needs a free Kaggle login, so this cell is not run when the book is built.

Answers to Predict the play

Answer 1.

A tite front in nickel: a 3-3-5 by the count. Three hands down inside the tackles (a 4i, a 0 and a 4i) with a stand-up edge on each side make five on the line, and one linebacker stands behind them.

Six in the box against six blockers (five linemen and the tight end), with two safeties deep and the nickel outside the box. On paper that is a light box, and analysts will tell you to run against light boxes. But this light box was *built* to be run into. Inside zone aims at the play-side B gap, where the 4i is; the nose and the 4is will occupy all five offensive linemen, and the Mike will run free, as in Figure 4.

The better calls test what the tite gives up. Outside zone or a toss to the tight-end side makes the tight end block a stand-up edge alone and asks the Mike and the strong safety to beat the ball to the alley. A run with the quarterback reading the backside edge (a zone read) turns the unblocked edge into a wasted defender. Or don't run at all: a single linebacker in a light box is exactly the defender an RPO or a quick throw underneath attacks. The defense has dared you to run inside; the smart offense declines.

Answer 2.

Front B is the better bet against this opponent, though neither is free. Outside zone lives on reach blocks. In Front B, the defenders on the play side are all *outside* the men who must reach them: the 3 outside the right guard, the end outside the tight end. Those are the hardest reaches in football, and a quick 3-technique can be through the B gap before the guard gets there (the one-gap animation in Defensive Line Play). If the reaches fail, the back can't get outside and has to cut up early, into two linebackers.

In Front A, the play-side 4i and the nose are *inside* their blockers, the easiest reaches there are, so the line can get its heads across and run the defense sideways. Everything then rests on one edge holding the tight end, an excellent blocker, by himself, with one linebacker and a safety coming from depth to fill the alley. Expect the ball to bounce outside if the edge is reached, or to cut back if the Mike over-runs it.

What Front B gives up: the interior. Against the same team's *inside* zone, the 1 and the 3 can be doubled and the doubles can climb to two linebackers. That is why defenses facing an outside-zone team mix fronts by down and formation instead of living in one, and why the title's teams widen their edges (or switch to four-man fronts) against wide-zone offenses.

Answer 3.

Snap A is two-gap. Head-up alignments (a 0 and two 4s) and first steps straight *into* the blockers are the signature: each lineman is striking the man in front of him, about to lock out and read. That means three linemen are holding six gaps, the edge on the tight end has the D gap, and **both inside linebackers are free:** they have no gap of their own at the snap and will read and fill wherever the ball goes. If the linemen win, nobody blocks either of them.

Snap B is one-gap. Shaded alignments (a 3, a 1 and a 5) and first steps *into the gaps* beside the blockers: the nose into the A gap toward the tight end, the left end into the B gap, the right end into the C gap. Every lineman has one gap, so the linebackers have one each too: the Mike the B gap toward the tight end, the Will the other A gap, as in the right half of Figure 3. **Nobody is free,** but everybody is fast. This is the Under-like 3-4 that Wade Phillips ran for decades.

The lesson is the one this chapter keeps repeating: the roster said 3-4 both times. The alignment and the first step told you which 3-4.